

Case Form Usability Test Plan

US Tax Court Case Management Tool Project
October/November 2019

Overview

Flexion UX researchers will conduct a usability study for the “File a Petition” process of the USTC case management tool. The study is designed to gather feedback from participants who will use the case management tool to file petitions.

All interviews will be conducted remotely.

Testing Goals

1. Does the user understand the content as presented?
2. Does the user have any doubts about what they need to do to proceed with the petition?
3. After reading the instructions, can the user clearly state what documents they will need to proceed with the petition?

File a Petition

1. Can the user easily complete the form wizard? Are the steps logically ordered? Are instructions clear?
2. Is the user able to select the correct party type, case type based on the provided data?
3. Does the user understand the Review Screen? Is this helpful to them?

File a Document

1. Can the user easily locate how to file a document in a case?
2. Are instructions clear? Does the user understand how to prepare their documents?
3. Is the user able to locate the correct document type? How do they search for a document type?
4. Can the user easily complete the File a Document form?
5. Does the user understand the “extra” items that can be included? Is the helper text useful?
6. Does the user understand information on the docket record?
7. Are they able to navigate between their documents?

Screening for Petitioner Test Subjects

Flexion will recruit 15-20 participants with the goal of completing 8-12 interviews. The target participant mix will be:

Timing: Sprint 26

Who are the petitioner test subjects?

- Age (target 4 participants in each range)
 - 18-39
 - 40-65
 - Over 65
- Location (target 3 participants in each range)
 - EST
 - CST
 - MT
 - PST
- Knowledge to the process
 - Never filed a petition before
 - Have filed before (target 3 participants)
- Diverse gender mix, if possible - target is 50/50, male/female

Recruiting Schedule

Flexion will reach out to friends and family via social media and personal connections. Interested parties will respond to Pratik Vyas with availability, and he will schedule all interviews.

Interviews will take place the first week of November. If the level of participation is low or if interviews are challenging to schedule, additional interviews may be conducted the following week as well.

In order to accommodate as many participants as possible, Flexion will schedule interviews with participants between the hours of 8am and 6pm EST, Monday through Friday. If additional flexibility is needed, Flexion will make reasonable accommodations.

Recruitment letter for social media

I'm looking for a few volunteers to help a team at work improve a government website to make sure it works well for the public who'll be using it. It would only take 30 minutes and can be done virtually (so doesn't matter where you live). You'll be using the website to file a fake petition contesting your taxes to the United States Tax Court. If you've actually done this in real life, even better!

If you're interested and over 18 years of age, contact Pratik Vyas at pvyas@flexion.us

Findings Analysis and Presentation

Daily updates will be provided during standup on recruiting efforts, interviews scheduled, and interviews completed. Within two weeks of the conclusion of interviews, study results will be shared with the internal UX design team. Within three days of the internal team review, the results analysis will be shared with the entire Flexion and USTC team and stakeholders.

Methodology

Interviews will be 30 minutes in length and will be conducted remotely using Zoom. In-person interviews will also be conducted where feasible. Each interview will have a separate Flexion moderator and note-taker.

The “File a Petition” form prototype will be used for all sessions:

<http://ui-stg.ustc-case-mgmt.flexion.us>. This is a fully functioning system and not a clickable prototype or wireframe.

Each participant will be assigned one of five different scenarios. Prior to their session, they’ll receive an email confirming the time of the interview, their login information, and an IRS notice that corresponds with their testing scenario.

They will be asked to save the notice to their hard drive before the test so that it can be easily accessed during the session. Users will also be asked to test the Zoom software prior to the session, to ensure they are able to open and use the tool. If users have trouble using the tool, the moderator will attempt to walk them through the process. Alternate tools are available for participants who have issues using Zoom (like join.me, Skype, GoToMeeting).

The moderator will provide a brief introduction, including background information on the project and the importance of usability testing, at the beginning of the session. Participants will be encouraged to use the think-aloud protocol, meaning they will be encouraged to talk through tasks as they complete them, allowing the moderator to understand their thought process as they move through the system.

Sample Introduction

Thank you for agreeing to spend time with us today. As we mentioned in the invitation, Flexion is designing a tool for the U.S. Tax Court to allow taxpayers to file cases online. As part of this process, we’re gathering feedback from taxpayers on our designs.

Today we’ll be taking a look at the petition filing process. I’ll ask you to complete some steps to access an account, upload documents, and complete the file a petition process as if you were a taxpayer who had received a notice from the IRS. Were you able to download the .pdf we sent?

While you’re completing the tasks, I ask that you think aloud, so that I can understand your thought process and the decisions you make. I may ask you questions about your process, and I want to stress that there are no wrong answers. We’re testing the prototype, not you, so you

can't make any mistakes. Any information you share with me will be helpful, and I'll make note of it. Our goal is to make the tool as easy and user friendly as possible, and your feedback will help us understand what works well, and also help us understand where we might be able to make improvements or adjustments. Also, your comments today are anonymous and your name won't be associated with any feedback you share.

Do you have any questions before we begin?

[If the participant has downloaded the .pdf to their hard drive, continue to Scenario 1.

If the participant has not downloaded the .pdf, walk them through the process, then continue to Scenario 1.]

Moderators Guide

Each of the 5 scenarios has two primary tasks:

1. File a Petition
2. File a Document

Scenario 1 - File a petition for myself

File a Petition - File a petition notice of deficiency for myself

You have received a Notice of Deficiency from the IRS for the amount of \$15,000.

File a Document - Primary document, nonstandard document type

The IRS has filed a Request For Admissions in your case, and you have prepared a document responding to this action. You want to submit your document to the Court online.

Internal notes:

- *Can the user figure out which document type [Response] given the information?*
- *Is the user able to select the previous document [Request for Admissions]?*

Scenario 2 - File a petition for myself & spouse

File a Petition - File a petition, Notice of determination concerning collection action, for myself & spouse

You and your spouse have received a Notice of Deficiency from the IRS for the amount of \$15,000.

File a Document - Petitioner and Spouse file primary document

You and your spouse have filed a petition. You've moved and now you would like to change your requested place of trial to [placeholder]. You've prepared a motion to do so, and would like to submit the document to the Court online.

Internal notes:

- *Can the user figure out which document type [Motion to Change Place of Trial] given the information?*
- *Does the user understand the filing parties? Do they select both parties correctly?*

Scenario 3 - File a petition for a business

File a Petition - File a petition, Readjustment of partnership items code 6226, Business partnership

You and your partner have received a Readjustment of partnership items code 6226 against your business.

File a Document - Primary document and supporting document

Your case has been scheduled for trial, but you will not be able to attend due to medical reasons. You've spoken with the court, and have prepared a Motion to Be Excused from Appearing at the Trial Session to file with the Court. You also have a signed affidavit from your physician, Dr. Samuel Ozburn, that you want to file to endorse your motion.

Internal notes:

- *Does the user understand what a supporting document is?*
- *Are they able to figure out where to add their supporting document? Do they upload the document to the correct field?*
- *Are the fields related to the affidavit clear? Is language familiar to the user?*

Scenario 4 - File a petition worker classification

File a Petition - File a petition, Notice of determination of worker classification, Business corporation

Your business has received a Notice of determination of worker classification from the IRS.

File a Document - Primary document and Certificate of Service

You want to request that the Court reschedule your hearing, and have prepared a Motion for Continuance to submit online. Your spouse is also on the case, but does not live at the same address and you must serve this document to them by paper, along with a Certificate of Service.

Internal notes:

- *Does the user understand what a Certificate of Service is?*
- *How does the user expect to include the COS? Do they understand to scan the COS along with their primary document?*
- *Are the COS input fields clear and understandable?*

Scenario 5 - File a petition whistleblower

File a Petition - File a petition, Notice of determination under section 7623 concerning whistleblower action, Other estate or trust

You have received a Notice of determination under section 7623 concerning whistleblower action on the estate of John Doe from the IRS.

File a Document - Primary document and Attachment

You have been working with the IRS attorney on your case to prepare an agreed Stipulation of Facts. You also want to include an additional document as an exhibit with your stipulation.

Internal notes:

- *Does the user understand what other documents they can include with their filing?*
- *Do they refer to the instructional text? What do they find useful? Not useful?*
- *How does the user expect to include the exhibit? Do they understand to scan the exhibit along with their primary document?*

Task 1: File a Petition Observation Questions

- Login to system
- **Step 1- Upload your Statement of Taxpayer Identification**
 - Did the user select the correct document? Did they understand this was what they had filled out/scanned/file on the computer? *internal note
- **Step 2 -Tell Us About Your Petition**
 - Did the user select the case/notice they received, if they received one? If they did not receive a notice, did they choose the correct case/notice for the petition they are filing? *internal note
- **Step 3- Who are you filing this petition for?**
 - Did the user select the correct radio button for who they are filling for? Did they second guess themselves? Were they quick to select or take a moment to decide? *internal note
- **Step 4- How do you want this case handled?**
 - Was helper text helpful to the user? Did the user read it? Was the user able to make the correct decision between regular and small cases? Were they confident in their answer? Was the user able to easily select the place of trial? *internal note
- **Step 5- Review your petition**

- Does the user review the entire screen before submitting? Do they have any questions or concerns about filing? Is there anything on this page they think is missing or would be helpful to have here? *internal note
- **View Confirmation**
 - Was there anything that was not on the tips page that would have been helpful to the user while preparing for filing the petition?
 - Was there anything that the user read on the tips page that mislead them while going through the petition process?

Task 2 - File a Document Observation Questions

[Assumption: Participant has successfully completed Task 1: File a Petition]

- **Step 1: Dashboard**
 - Can the user locate the correct case from their dashboard?
- **Step 2: Case Detail**
 - Does the user understand the information on this page?
 - Are they able to navigate through the case information and docket record easily?
 - Is the user able to easily locate the “File a Document” action? What does this mean to the user? Does the language match their expectations?
- **Step 3: Before You File**
 - Does the user understand what they need to upload with their document?
 - Can the user identify what information applies to their scenario?
 - Is information presented in an easy to understand format? Is the user overwhelmed?
 - Is the timing of this information appropriate? Would users like to see this information elsewhere (earlier in the process, later in process, etc.)?
 - Does the user understand the redaction messaging?
- **Step 4: What Document are you Filing?**
 - How does the user determine which document type they need to file (given their scenario)?
 - If a user is unsure of what document type to select, how do they proceed? Do they notice and understand the tips section?
 - How does the user select their document type? Do they use the typeahead feature? Do they know typeahead is available?

- Is the labelling for the nonstandard fields clear? Do users understand what they need to enter?
- What are user expectations around how much information they will need to enter, how many steps? Do they understand where they are in the process of completing the form?
- **Step 5: File a Document Form**
 - Do users understand which PDF they need to upload in which field (for multiple documents)
 - Do users understand (or recall from the first step) what “extra items” are? Are they able to select the items that apply to them (depending on scenario)?
 - Do users notice and understand the tool tip? Does the information help them make a more informed decision?
 - Are users able to determine if they have a supporting document (depending on their scenario)? Are they able to add this supporting document?
 - Are users able to select the appropriate filing parties? Is the language clear for them to make that determination?
 - How does the user move through the form? Do they complete each field in sequence? Do they need to return to previous steps, and if so, are they able to do so?
- **Step 6: Review Filing**
 - Is the information presented in a clear format? Are users able to identify the different pieces of information easily?
 - Do users understand how to view their uploaded documents?
 - Are users able to make changes to their filing information? How do they expect to be able to make edits?
 - Does the information presented make the user confident about submitting the form?
 - Does the user read and understand the “reminders”? How do they feel about seeing this information during this step?
- **Step 7: Confirmation**
 - How does the user feel after they have submitted their filing?
 - Does the confirmation page meet their expectations? What information do they expect to see?

Test Data Needs

What does Flexion and the Court need to prepare in advance to ensure usability testing mirrors real life scenarios as much as possible with the artifacts that the users would have in advance.

TASK 1: “File a Petition” Test Data Needs:

Scenario 1 for Filing a Petition

- A Notice of Deficiency single person from the IRS for the amount of \$15,000
- A written Petition for a single person

Scenario 2 for Filing a Petition

- A Notice of determination concerning collection action from the IRS for the amount of \$15,000
- A written petition for a person and their spouse

Scenario 3 for Filing a Petition

- A Readjustment of partnership items code 6226 for a business owner and partner
- A written petition for a business partnership

Scenario 4 for Filing a Petition

- A Notice of determination of worker classification for a business
- A written petition for a business

Scenario 5 for Filing a Petition

- A Notice of determination under section 7623 concerning whistleblower action on the estate of John Doe from the IRS
- A written petition for an estate with executor

TASK 2: “File a Document” Test Data Needs:

Scenario 1 (Primary document , nonstandard document type)

- Response Document
- Request for Admissions Document

Scenario 2 (Petitioner and Spouse file primary document)

- Motion to Change Place of Trial Document signed by both myself and spouse

Scenario 3 (Primary document and supporting document)

- Motion to Be Excused from Appearing
- Signed Affidavit From Physician Document (Dr. Samuel Ozburn)

Scenario 4 (Primary document and Certificate of Service)

- Motion for Continuance to Submit Online
- Certificate of Service

Scenario 5 (Primary document and Attachment)

- An agreed Stipulation of Facts Document
- Additional Document (Exhibit)